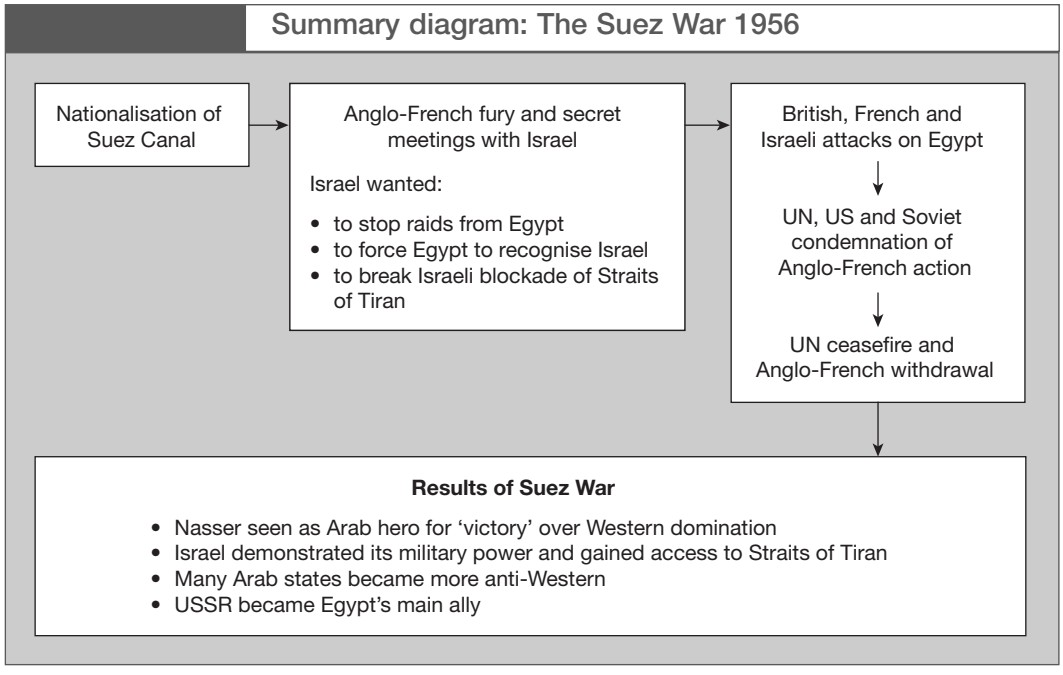


3 | The Causes of the Six-Day War 1967

In its results the Six-Day War was the most dramatic of all the Arab–Israeli wars, yet it was the one that both sides wanted least. Before we study the events leading to war, we will look briefly at how Israel had developed since its creation as a new state.

Key question
How did Israel develop into a strong, modern state?

The development of Israel

Since the end of the war in 1949, the Israelis had lived with the threat of invasion. They knew they were surrounded by enemies and were convinced that the Arabs would try to attack again. Soon after the fighting had ended in 1949, the Secretary of the Arab League, which represents all Arab states, said:

> As long as we don't make peace with the Zionists the war is not over. And as long as the war is not over there is neither winner nor loser. As soon as we recognise the existence of Israel, we admit, by this act, that we are defeated.

Not surprisingly, the Israeli Defence Forces would have to be constantly on the alert. The Israeli army not only defended the new nation; it also helped to shape it. The Jews of Israel had come from different parts of Europe and the USA and, after 1949, nearly 700,000 new immigrants arrived. The 'Law of Return' gives any Jew in the world the right to become a citizen of Israel. Many of the new immigrants were from north Africa and other parts of the Middle East. In the army they all received a similar training, lived together and had to learn Hebrew, the